



Ages 14 to 18

Abuse at Home: Getting Help

What abuse at home can look like, what the law says about physical punishment, and how to get help for yourself or a friend. For all students.

Before You Read

This guide covers physical and emotional abuse at home, and fear of going home.

This guide is about abuse by adults at home, including physical punishment that hurts, emotional abuse and neglect. Some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with something that has happened to you or someone close to you.

- Read it in sections, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free and confidential, any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.
- **Shout:** text SHOUT to 85258, free, 24/7.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

This guide is for **all students**. It explains what abuse at home can look like, what the law says about physical punishment, how to get help, and how to support a friend.

- Abuse at home happens in **every kind of family**, including families that seem successful or strict "for your own good".
- It may come from a **parent, step-parent, carer, relative, guardian or host family**, or another adult you live or stay with.
- If it's happening to you, **it is not your fault**, whatever your marks, your behaviour or anyone's expectations.

Need Help Now?

- **Tell an adult you trust:** a teacher, your tutor, a house parent or anyone at school you feel safe with.
- If someone has threatened you or someone else, **tell an adult straight away.**
- If you're **scared to go home today**, tell an adult at school **before the end of the school day.**
- If someone is in danger right now, **call 999.**
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free, any time.

Key Words

Physical abuse

Deliberately hurting a child's body, for example hitting, kicking, shaking, burning, or hitting with an object such as a belt.

Emotional abuse

Persistently making a child feel worthless, unloved, frightened or valued only when they meet someone else's expectations.

Neglect

Persistently failing to meet a child's basic needs, including keeping them safe, fed, clothed and cared for when ill.

Sexual abuse

Forcing, pressuring or tricking a child into sexual activity of any kind, in person or online.

Significant harm

The level of harm, or risk of it, at which children's social care must look into what is happening to protect a child.

DSL

The Designated Safeguarding Lead: the member of staff responsible for keeping students safe and working with other agencies.

These are the four categories of abuse that schools use. They often overlap: being hurt usually comes with fear, which is emotional harm too.

Discipline or Abuse?

Discipline

- Clear rules and fair consequences, like losing screen time or going out
- High expectations, explained and supported
- Adults who get angry sometimes, but don't hurt you or make you afraid of them

Warning Signs of Abuse

- Being hit, kicked, shaken, or hit with a belt, a shoe or anything else
- Injuries, marks or bruises from "punishment"
- Being afraid to go home, or of results and reports reaching home
- Constant put-downs, threats, or being told you're a disgrace to the family
- Being told to hide injuries or keep things secret

"It's Just How I Was Brought Up"

Culture, religion, stress and high expectations can explain why an adult behaves the way they do. **They never make it OK to hurt you. You don't need to wait for it to happen again before asking for help.**

What the Law Says

England, Wales and Scotland

- **In Wales and Scotland**, the law no longer allows adults to defend physical punishment of a child as "reasonable punishment".
- **In England**, a parent accused of hitting a child can still, in some cases, argue it was "reasonable punishment". But they **cannot** use that argument for more serious assaults, including where a child suffers actual bodily harm, and it does not apply to child cruelty.
- Whether a crime has happened is for the police and the courts to decide, **not you**. You never have to prove anything before you tell someone.
- Separately from the criminal law, **children's social care** must look into what is happening if there's reason to think a child is suffering, or likely to suffer, significant harm.

Sources: Children Act 2004, section 58; Children (Abolition of Defence of Reasonable Punishment) (Wales) Act 2020; Children (Equal Protection from Assault) (Scotland) Act 2019. Checked September 2026.

You won't be in trouble for asking for help. Schools respond to this as a safeguarding matter: their job is to keep you safe.

You're Not the Only One

16.5%

of adults in England and Wales say they experienced physical abuse by an adult before they were 18

ONS, 2025

29.0%

say they experienced some form of abuse before they were 18

ONS, 2025

From the Crime Survey for England and Wales (year ending March 2024, published November 2025), asking adults aged 18 and over. The people most often named as responsible for physical abuse were fathers and mothers. Checked September 2026.

Sources: check them yourself

- Office for National Statistics, *Abuse during childhood in England and Wales: year ending March 2024* (published 5 November 2025)

How to Tell

- **Any adult at school you trust** can help. They will pass it to the safeguarding team.
- Start simply: "Can I talk to you about something at home?" You can also write it down, or email a teacher asking to talk.
- **You don't have to show anyone your injuries.** Telling is enough. Staff won't photograph or examine you; if a medical check is needed, it is arranged properly.
- If you're worried about a younger brother or sister, say so. **It isn't your job to protect them on your own.**
- If the first person doesn't help, tell someone else. Keep going until someone listens.

What Happens When You Tell

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with a person you trust. Behind them is a system:** a safeguarding team, records and procedures that make sure what you tell one person reaches the people who can help. The person is why young people tell; the system is why telling works.

- You'll be listened to and taken seriously.
- **The school won't simply phone home.** The safeguarding team will think first about your safety, and may speak to children's social care, and sometimes the police, before deciding who tells your parents, what and when.
- The adult will pass it to the safeguarding team. They won't promise to keep it secret, and they'll tell you what they are doing.
- The law allows schools to share information needed to keep a young person safe without asking for consent, and from 30 September 2026 a new legal duty requires many safeguarding organisations to share it. What is shared must be relevant and proportionate, go only to the people who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Because your consent isn't the legal basis, they won't ask for it as if it were. They should tell you what they are sharing, with whom and why, unless that would put someone at risk, and listen to what you think. Agreeing to support, such as counselling, is a separate choice, and your views matter there.
- You'll have as much say as possible in the plan and the support you get.

If You're Scared to Go Home

- Say it clearly: "I don't feel safe going home."
- The safeguarding team will work with children's social care to decide what happens, aiming to do this before the end of the school day.
- They may not be able to promise a particular outcome, but they should keep you informed and listen to your views.

Social Workers and Police

- A social worker may want to talk to you, usually on your own, to understand what's happening and what you want.
- Your wishes and feelings matter to their decisions, even when they can't do exactly what you ask.
- If the police are involved, their job includes keeping you safe. You won't be in trouble for telling.

If You're Worried About a Friend: RESPOND

Young people often tell a friend before they tell an adult. That makes you part of how people get help. RESPOND has three parts for students: **you lead the relational steps**, **Pause is the bridge**, and

adults lead the systems steps.

Relational: You Lead (R, E, S)

R Recognise

Notice the signs.

- Is your friend frightened of going home, or of results reaching home?
- Do they hide marks, avoid changing for PE, or flinch?
- Use the 4 Ps: **People** (who's at home?), **Places** (home, weekends, holidays), **Platforms** (messages from home that scare them), **Patterns** (does it happen after tests or reports?)
- You don't need certainty to act

E Engage

Make contact. Listen.

- "You seemed really worried about that test. Is everything OK at home?"
- Listen without judging their family, and don't ask to see injuries
- **If you see someone being hurt or threatened**, the safest options are to **Delegate** (get an adult, or call 999 if someone is in danger), **Distract** (give your friend a reason to come with you) and **Delay** (check in privately afterwards). Don't confront an adult or get physically involved

S Support

Stay close.

- "It's not your fault. You don't have to deal with this on your own. Let's talk to someone together."

The Bridge: Pause (P)



Pause

Slow down before you act.

- Ask: **Risk** (is anyone in danger, or scared to go home today?), **Rights** (what does my friend need?), **Resources** (who can help?)
- Don't contact their family, post about it, or promise to keep it secret
- You're not expected to investigate, collect evidence or protect them yourself. That is the adults' job

Systems: Adults Lead (O, N, D)



Offer

Model alternatives. Signpost help.

- Tell your friend help is available, and offer to go with them



Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- Tell a trusted adult the same day, **even if your friend asks you not to**. Tell your friend what you're going to do, if you can
- If they're scared to go home, tell an adult before the end of the school day
- It isn't betraying them. It's how they get protected



Document

Adults record it.

- The adult makes the formal record. Tell them clearly what you saw and heard



Staying Safe Online

- If you share a phone, laptop or tablet at home, or someone checks your phone, **they may be able to see what you've looked at**.
- The Childline website has a **"Hide page" button** on every page, so you can leave it quickly.

- Childline explains how to use **private browsing** and **clear your history**. If a device has monitoring software, these may not hide what you're doing, so a school or library computer can be safer.
- Calls to Childline won't show up on most phone bills, but may show in your phone's call log.
- Read more: Childline: cover your tracks.

If You're 16, 17 or 18

- **If you're 16 or 17**, you're still a child in safeguarding law, and everything in this guide applies to you. Your views carry real weight in any plan.
- **If you're 18**, you're legally an adult. The school can still help and will think about your safety and wellbeing, but the support routes are different and your own choices count in a different way.
- If there's abuse between adults at home, the **National Domestic Abuse Helpline** (for adults, 0808 2000 247, 24 hours) can help an adult who is being harmed.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It's discipline, not abuse"	Rules and consequences are discipline. Being hurt, injured or made afraid is not OK, whatever it's called.
"I got bad marks, so I brought it on myself"	No one deserves to be hurt. Adults are responsible for their own behaviour.
"It's my culture, so no one can help"	Every family and culture is respected, but culture never makes harm to a child OK. Help is there for everyone.
"Telling will split my family up"	The aim is to keep you safe, and help often means support for the family. Adults should explain what happens at each step.

If You Board

- **You can always contact your house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.**
- If you're dreading going home for an exeat, half term or the holidays, or staying with a guardian or host family, **tell a house parent or the DSL before you travel.** There is time to make a plan.
- Your boarding school has an independent person you can talk to who isn't a member of staff.
- You can always contact your family privately.
- If an adult at home is the person hurting you, tell a house parent or the DSL; they will help you stay safe when you are in touch with home.

Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor or advisor, your head of year, a teacher, a coach, the school nurse, a counsellor, or a house parent if you board
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline (for anyone under 19):** 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **If you're under 18, start here.** Childline: physical abuse
- **Shout:** text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- **NSPCC Helpline:** 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk. It is for adults worried about a child; a trusted adult could call it with you or for you
- **Emergency:** call 999 if you or someone else is in immediate danger

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

Abuse at Home: Getting Help: Student Guide 6 - 14 to 18

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